France: The Third Way

In contrast to the UK and Russia, France is a relatively newer diplomatic discovery, one whose colonial past has receded more in public consciousness. The minimal overhang of history offers it opportunities, just as its focus encourages growth of select domains.

For two decades now, this relationship has been steadily advancing, free from surprises and shifts triggered by external factors. The two nations not only share values and beliefs but put considerable emphasis on building national capabilities. Both of them navigated the Cold War era trying to maximize their strategic space. In modern times, they have developed strong convergences that go back to the 1950s. Since then, succeeding generations of French platforms and equipment have been an integral part of the Indian military force. India, therefore, has good reasons to see it as a major partner for its national security.

France was also an important influence in the development of India's strategic thinking, especially its nuclear-force posture. Indeed, the very concept of credible minimum deterrence was derived from the learnings of the French experience. Not just that, after the 1998 nuclear tests, this nation was the first nuclear power to show an understanding of our strategic compulsions. So, it was no surprise that PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee made Paris his first bilateral stop after the nuclear tests. Along with President Jacques Chirac, he launched the strategic partnership between our two countries that still serves us well till today. French support played an important role in India getting an exemption from the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) in 2008 to resume international cooperation in civil nuclear energy.

In the UNSC and other international forums, where competing and complex sets of interests affect choices, France has been a consistent partner. Our synergies have enabled us, for example, to be more effective in mobilizing UN action against terrorism and terrorist groups. France has also been a forthright supporter of India's case for permanent membership of the UNSC.

In the past few years, the uncertainties and disequilibrium of a world in transition have encouraged a stronger sense of common strategic purpose. Among the current priorities, one is to cooperate more closely in the Indo-Pacific, where India is in the middle and France present at its bookends. It